

Lock down the labs

Google has announced plans to shut down its Google Labs web site. Labs, a source of tricks, hacks and gizmos the world over, is the latest casualty after Google Health and Google PowerMeter. Many Android apps created here will continue to be available on Android Market

No naked scans

A new software for screening of travellers at the US airports will address the general public concern over full-body scanners

to cannibalise earlier generations.

Meanwhile sometime amid all these shifts, Apple released its iPod Touch - a device that was pretty much an iPhone sans the phone! In hindsight, could technology historians one day look at this as Apple's last attempt to save a dying franchise? Perhaps. The iPod Touch now honestly seems like an anachronism, a device that belongs to another age. Developments such as these surely indicate that the epoch of the iPod and the PMP may finally be over.

What else is changing?

Apart from hardware on existing devices like smartphones and the emergence of a newer class of devices such as tablets, there are certain game-changing transformations in the offing. Just like digitisation, audio compression and piracy laid the perfect groundwork for the entry of the iPod, certain trends are occurring as we speak that will lay the foundation for a shift away from the PMP. We're now witnessing a paradigm shift in the way media is consumed. We've gone from hoarding music to now being open to streaming music as and when we need. Think about it, when was the last time you thought of a song and played it from your "collection"? At least we've not for the longest time. Why would anyone? Streaming is perfectly legal and instant.

With bandwidth finally starting to become readily available people just

stream music from the numerous services available. Streaming services even provide curated lists, algorithmically generated recommendations, listening statistics and loads of other features, thereby adding another layer of functionality to the user experience. With 3G and next generation wireless data services being implemented, soon enough, you'll be doing the same on your smartphone or tablet. By then, battery would (hopefully) not be a problem either. Instead of trying to cram nearly endless collections on to your device you'd simply be able to tap into the infinite backup that is the internet. Sorry, we meant cloud.

Disclaimers

Of course we weren't going to make seemingly ludicrous claims without appropriate disclaimers. While all of the points we've spoken about so far certainly indicate that the discreet PMP is certainly on it's way out, there will be certain caveats.



One possible argument in favour of the PMP could be that the PMP will evolve into something better. But what? If a PMP one day lets you make calls and connect to a data connection its functionality as a phone supersedes that as a PMP. If it becomes large enough to be a tablet, it'll be called a tablet. The logic is akin to saying that the device in my pocket is essentially a calculator that can make calls.

Another more valid argument in favour of the dying device can be found in certain niche spheres where the PMP

may still dig its heels firmly into the ground. There'll be the odd person going, "but I like to wear my itty-bitty Shuffle on my official Nike sports arm band for my morning run". Sure there's no perfect substitute for you. But what we must realise is that this sort of thing will become more and more rare as we go along. Smartphones of today will not only keep you pumped up with your favourite tunes, but also track your run. Apps will give you all sorts of data on calories burnt and some such.

The other category of readers who'd by now have turned blue trying to contain their opinions are audiophiles. Or more appropriately pseudo-audiophiles who swear by the iPod's superior components. These are guys who'd wax eloquent about the Wolfson DAC on their iPod like it's God's greatest gift to mankind, but really, it's not. To truly up the iPod's audiophile quotient you need to implement mods at both, the software and hardware level. For instance, to play FLAC you need to Rockbox the firmware. But all this is beside the point. Most of us are satisfied with decent quality audio on the go coupled with good UX which today's range of smartphones easily provide. Who cares if you can't hear the faint rustle of the lead vocalist scratching his privates which the recording might have picked up? ■

WHAT ELSE COULD BE DEAD SOONER THAN LATER?

With smartphones and tablets evolving beyond what was thought possible here are some of the other things of everyday use that face possible imminent extinction:



GPS devices: With accessories such as car docks and map packages constantly being updated with up-to-date POI data, who would need a dedicated GPS device?



Point and shoot cameras: With sensor sizes increasing, it may not be a stretch of one's imagination if this product category disappears.

Magazines/Newspapers: Yes,



with a heavy heart we must acknowledge that the reading experience that tablets, phones, and eReaders offer is superlative.

Of course Digit will live on, it'll just be on your electronic device.



Plastic/Money: With NFC and other such technologies, phones may one day be your payment gateway.



Handheld gaming consoles: When tablets soon start packing in SoCs like the Tegra 3, which is rumoured to have a 12-Core NVIDIA GPU, the possibilities are limitless.